

AI Agent Design: Weekly Time Reporting

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The problem

A new requirement asked a marketing and communications team to log weekly hours against 10 official activity categories in a project tracking platform. There was no mapping between people's real work and those categories, and no tooling to help, so reporting depended on memory and invited inconsistency.

The approach

I started from a colleague's existing agent, mapped what could be adapted and what had to be built new, and documented that line throughout. The agent runs a six-step weekly cycle: profile check, scan of the week's signals, a categorized draft, interpretation flags, user review with a confidence column, and a submission-ready final.

Design decisions

- **Scan first, not interview first.** The agent drafts a profile from signals it can already see, and the user corrects it. Correcting is easier than creating, which is the difference between a tool people try once and one they keep.
- **Negative knowledge as a field.** A "known distinctions and exclusions" field tells the agent what work is not, so look-alike work stops being miscategorized week after week.
- **Specific update suggestions.** After each draft, the agent proposes concrete profile changes based on what it saw, instead of asking a vague "anything to update?"
- **Ownership levels over flat lists.** Own, Lead, Contribute, Advise or Monitor tells the agent how to weigh each program's hours.

What shipped

- A team guide and system prompt, a categorization guide, a setup scan method, a recurring Friday calendar reminder with setup guide, and a new-features summary for the original agent's author.
- Quality control built into the release: inaccurate time-increment language was caught and corrected across every deliverable before launch.
- Deployed to the team, with collaborator feedback gathered and follow-on improvements scoped.

Skills demonstrated

AI agent design · Product thinking · Prompt engineering · Adoption design · Technical writing · Building on a colleague's work